Artist Talk: The use of Midi-Instruments as performance tools in Jazz and Fusion Improvisation

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Abstract

This session focuses on midi-instruments and their use in jazz and fusion genres. Colin Hemmingsen and Leigh Jackson represent the Midi-Performance Research Centre recently established at Massey University in Wellington as part of the Conservatorium of Music. The talk will contain demonstrations of the unique functions and extended parameters that the WX-7 wind controller features with emphasis on the use of breath control to create expression. The use of midi-guitar in conjunction with the G4 powerbook to model tube amplifiers and to create solo sounds specifically suited to the guitar will be demonstrated.

Also the polyphonic capabilities of the midi-guitar and how sounds can be layered on separate strings to produce an expressive multi-instrument that can be played in real time. The session will explore the issues encountered specifically with the playing of these instruments in Jazz improvisation and how these were managed in performance during a recent recording project. Issues relating to latency and articulation and how these impact on the improviser's expression will also be discussed.
A short performance will include a practical demonstration of how these instruments function in Jazz and Fusion setting.

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